Symbolic and Pretend Play Emerge Across the Second Year

Object substitution and simple pretense commonly become visible between about 12 and 24 months; this is a representational transition, not a required intelligence program or a diagnostic cutoff.

-TO-HIGH-EMERGENCE; MODERATE-MECHANISM; LOW-DIAGNOSTIC-CUTOFF | STATUS: DRAFT | DOMAIN: PLAY, COGNITION | REPL

WHAT WE KNOW (Narrowest Supported Conclusion)

Play is not one exposure. Belsky & Most (1981) described a cross-sectional sequence from exploratory object manipulation toward more symbolic acts across infancy. During the second year, many children begin treating an object or action as standing for something else. Lillard et al. (2013) take that developmental emergence as real while rejecting unique-necessity claims about later intelligence. Adjacent exploration-as-sampling.md and embodied-perception-action.md cover information-seeking and motor–perception coupling, not pretense.

EVIDENCE AND CAUSAL ASSESSMENT

Observational and cross-sectional studies show increasing nonliteral object use; they do not isolate a single cognitive module as the cause. Emergence is reciprocal with language, memory, social routines, and executive control. This card is not an intervention efficacy claim (see pretend-play-educational-claims.md). Toddler peer coordination is toddler-peer-interaction.md.

EFFECT SIZE AND PERSISTENCE

Age windows are descriptive. Complexity expands with partners, materials, and language. There is no portable effect size for “more pretend.”

BIAS, HETEROGENEITY, AND CONFOUNDING

GI attenuation: n/a. Tasks underestimate children whose play is less verbal or culturally unfamiliar. Prop familiarity and adult scaffolding shape what is coded as pretense.

WHAT THIS DOES NOT MEAN (Strict Boundary Conditions)

A prescribed play sequence is not required. Variation in observed pretend play is not by itself pathology. More toys are not more representation. Play is not a manufactured intelligence program.

WHAT ACTION IS REASONABLY JUSTIFIED

Treat symbolic play as one observation among many. Forcing a script or ranking families by pretense frequency does not follow.

VERIFIED SOURCES & DOI IDENTIFIERS

- Belsky & Most (1981), Developmental Psychology
- Lillard et al. (2013), Psychological Bulletin